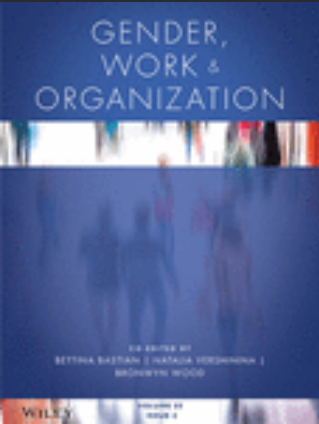


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<https://doi.org/10.1111/gwao.70133>

ISSN	0968-6673
eISSN	1468-0432
Received	25 March 2024
Revised	24 February 2026
Accepted	3 March 2026
Pages	n/a - n/a

ABSTRACT

Navigation icons: Previous, Information, Table of Contents, Images, Link

Gender, Work & Organization

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ORIGINAL ARTICLE OPEN ACCESS
Sexism and Gender-Washing in Academia and Beyond

Theorizing Patriarchy Against a Backdrop of Workplace Sexism and Stress in UK Academia

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Received: 25 March 2024 | Revised: 24 February 2026 | Accepted: 3 March 2026

Keywords: patriarchal gender regime | sexism | stress | UK neo-liberal higher education | women

ABSTRACT
Our analysis investigates the distinct relationship between sexism and workplace stress as experienced by women academics in the UK higher education system. We argue that due to the insufficient literature on this issue there is a limited knowledge base of the harmful psychological effects of stress in the workplace upon women academics in the UK university sector. In applying the concept of “gender regime” through a feminist lens we explain how the patriarchal, neoliberal university is a site of sexist discrimination, producing psychosocial health hazards in the workplace resulting in stressful experiences unique to women academics. The methodology employed in the study was a combined feminist and Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA) approach using semi-structured interviews to generate qualitative data. The sample included detailed interviews with seven women academics. Three themes were identified; *exclusion*, *discrimination*, and *gendered divisions of labor* as categories to illustrate how the gender regime manifests itself to cause stress in the workplace. Our data also suggested that the presence of men in leadership roles was associated with a higher frequency of sexist incidents compared to women-led management teams. To challenge such discrimination and the consequential experiences of workplace stress for women academics, we argue for recommendations that go beyond the micro agentic level implementing transformative change at the meso institutional level. These proposals include positive action equality programs, equitable and transparent recruitment/promotion procedures, access to full participation in all forms of academic work, statutory equality training programs for senior leadership postholders, and effective support mechanisms for employees with caring responsibilities. Simultaneously, we contend that any analysis of organizational gender regimes within UK universities needs to be recognized as originating from the wider macro patriarchal structural context.

1 | Introduction

Despite recognition of the “institutional peacocking” (Yarrow and Johnston 2022, 758) of gender equality work within UK higher education institutions (HEIs), contractual and workload inequalities are still very much evidenced when employment and progression data are examined. The majority of part-time workers in UK HEIs are women and less likely than men to be on open ended or permanent contracts (HESA 2024). Women on fractional contracts are more likely to work longer hours (UCU 2016), less likely to be in senior positions (Richards

et al. 2023; Fagan and Teasdale 2021), and less than one quarter of institutions in the United Kingdom have female Vice-Chancellors (Bachan and Bryson 2022). There also remains a significant variation in the gender pay gap statistics, up to a 41% median difference across all types of roles, with estimations that progress toward closing the gap is slowing down (HEP 2024). These disparities are uncomfortably at odds with the success experienced by the very graduates the system produces, with a majority of female enrollments who go on to earn more first-class honors degrees compared to their male peers (HESA 2023).

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Gender, Work & Organization, 2026, 00:1–13
<https://doi.org/10.1111/gwao.70133>

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Literature acknowledges the disproportionate degree of exposure to workplace stressors experienced by women (Biloudeau et al. 2020; Mukherjee 2024) and that the root of this is often as a result of the double burden of domestic labor with paid employment which can increase the risk of psychological distress (Väänänen et al. 2005). Consequently, this institutional tension between the private and public sphere contributes to increased levels of psychological distress amongst women, with the conflict caused by work impacting upon family, and vice versa.

Chancellors between the period of 2000–2019. Within their sample of 115 UK universities, 76% of this ultimate leadership position was occupied by men in 2019. Furthermore, other data confirmed this patriarchal presence in that 63 out of the 115 universities had never employed a female Vice Chancellor within the period of their study’s focus. This type of evidence unequivocally indicates the gendered nature of power between men and women within the sector, and how patriarchy is reproduced in hierarchical formations. Thus, the very essence of this study is rooted in the recognition of the institutional nature

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